

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-10

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Coverage window: the last ~24 hours of The Information's emailed editions (three Aug 9 dispatches: "The Briefing — AI's Software Winners and Losers", "AI Infrastructure — Microsoft's Capex Strategy Has Risks", and "Sunday Insights — Data Center Bans Top 500"), plus the exclusives they surfaced. Prices/moves are as reported by The Information, generally as of Friday 7 Aug close.

Key Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

1. Enterprise software is bifurcating into clear AI "winners" and "losers"

- **What:** The Briefing argues the software sector has split into firms that are monetising AI (Palantir, Shopify) and those AI is eroding (Canva, Figma, and — with an asterisk — Datadog).
- **Why:** Palantir's revenue jumped 89% in 1H26 selling AI agents plus human consultants; Shopify grew 34% as AI chatbots surface its merchants' structured product catalogue to shoppers. Meanwhile Canva is losing users to OpenAI's improved design model and cut its revenue-growth forecast; Figma guided to a ~12ppt Q3 growth slowdown; Datadog fell 19% in a day after warning a "leading AI company" would cut usage in Q3.
- **When:** Reported over the past week; stock levels cited as of Friday 7 Aug close.
- **Which:** Palantir (PLTR), Shopify (SHOP), Canva (private), Figma (FIG), Datadog (DDOG), OpenAI (private).
- **How:** Winners embed AI into existing workflows and data; losers face substitution (ChatGPT replacing point tools) or "spend-less" churn where customers stay but consume less. Palantir sits ~3.2% down YTD and Shopify ~5.9% down YTD after recovering most of a 1H sell-off that had reached ~40%; Figma finished the week down 38% YTD.
- **Link:** The Briefing, 9 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings>

2. Microsoft's "restrained" capex is partly an accounting and leasing story

- **What:** The Information details how Microsoft stayed free-cash-flow positive (\$19.6B in the June quarter) while rivals burned cash — a mix of heavy third-party data-center leasing and an accounting change.
- **Why:** From FY27 (1 July), Microsoft extended the assumed "useful life" of data centers and buildings from 15 to 25 years, shifting more new leases from finance leases (capex) to operating leases (opex) and trimming its 2026 calendar-year capex guide by \$15B (~8%). Critics (ex-Microsoft angel Charles Fitzgerald) say "the spend is the same... it just shows up on a different line item."
- **When:** Disclosed on the June-quarter earnings call; changes effective 1 July 2026.
- **Which:** Microsoft (MSFT); neocloud partners CoreWeave (CRWV), Nebius (NBIS), Nscale, Iren (IREN), Lambda; peers Amazon (AMZN), Alphabet (GOOGL); Nvidia (NVDA) hardware.
- **How:** Microsoft has committed ≥\$60B to neocloud providers (many five-year deals) and marks up that rented capacity to Azure customers such as OpenAI. Upside: speed and near-term cash preservation; risk: less cost control and exposure to future neocloud price hikes. Microsoft still guides Q1 FY27 capex up 43% to >\$50B.
- **Link:** "The Risks of Microsoft's Relatively Restrained Capex," 9 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/risks-microsoft-relatively-restrained-capex>

3. Local data-center bans top 500 — a growing constraint on AI compute

- **What:** The Information's tracker now counts 500+ active local bans/moratoriums on data centers nationwide, up from ~300 in late June.
- **Why:** Community pushback over power, water and grid strain accelerated sharply — 150+ towns and counties passed bans in July alone, many in emergency meetings — with New York enacting a first statewide prohibition and Texas ordering a pause on new grid connections pending an audit.
- **When:** July 2026 surge; tally as of the start of August.
- **Which:** Named AI compute buyers most exposed — Anthropic, Google (GOOGL), OpenAI; by extension all hyperscalers and neoclouds.
- **How:** Bans lengthen siting timelines and push development toward power-rich regions (e.g., Texas campuses), raising the strategic value of firms that control land, power and grid interconnects.
- **Link:** "Data Center Bans Top 500 as New York, Texas Join Pushback," 9 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/data-center-bans-top-500-new-york-texas-join-pushback>

4. Nvidia to invest up to \$3B in Blackstone-backed power developer Lancium

- **What:** Nvidia agreed to invest \$2B for a ~20% stake in Lancium — the power-infrastructure developer behind the OpenAI/Oracle "Stargate" campus in Abilene, Texas — with another \$1B committed as grid hookups are met.

- **Why:** Chips are useless without power; taking equity in a developer helps secure the electricity and interconnects that gate AI buildout, and gives Nvidia a stake in Stargate's expansion.
- **When:** Reported 7–8 Aug 2026; Lancium is exploring an IPO in 2027.
- **Which:** Nvidia (NVDA), Lancium (private, Blackstone-backed), Oracle (ORCL), OpenAI, SoftBank (Stargate partners).
- **How:** Direct equity into the “picks-and-shovels of the picks-and-shovels” — power — deepens Nvidia's vertical integration beyond silicon and reinforces the compute-power scarcity theme.
- **Link:** “Nvidia to Invest Up to \$3 Billion in Blackstone-Backed Power Firm Behind Stargate,” 8 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/nvidia-invest-3-billion-blackstone-backed-power-firm-behind-stargate>

5. Legal-AI startup Harvey in talks to raise at a \$15.5B valuation

- **What:** Harvey is in discussions to raise ≥\$500M at a \$15.5B valuation (including the new money), a ~40% step-up from its \$11B round five months ago.
- **Why:** Demand for vertical, workflow-specific AI is red-hot: Harvey's annualized revenue has jumped 80%+ since January, from ~\$190M to \$350M+.
- **When:** Reported the week of 4 Aug 2026; last round was March 2026.
- **Which:** Harvey (private); potential lead Lightspeed; existing backers include Sequoia, a16z, GIC, Coatue, Kleiner Perkins, Conviction, Elad Gil.
- **How:** Harvey deploys 25,000+ custom agents across contract analysis, due diligence, compliance and litigation for 1,300+ customers in 60 countries — a marker for private “applied-AI” valuations staying frothy.
- **Link:** “Harvey in Talks to Raise Funding at \$15.5 Billion Valuation,” 8 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/harvey-talks-raise-funding-15-5-billion-valuation>

6. This week's earnings: neoclouds CoreWeave and Nebius take the stage

- **What:** With big-tech earnings mostly done, the week's tech focus is two neoclouds. Consensus (S&P Global Market Intelligence): CoreWeave (Tue) revenue \$2.55B, +111%, EPS loss \$1.45; Nebius (Wed) revenue \$574.65M, +447%, EPS loss \$0.86.
 - **Why:** Neocloud results are a real-time read on AI compute demand and on the sustainability of the rent-vs-build model that hyperscalers (esp. Microsoft) increasingly rely on.
 - **When:** CoreWeave Tuesday 11 Aug; Nebius Wednesday 12 Aug 2026.
 - **Which:** CoreWeave (CRWV), Nebius (NBIS); read-through to Microsoft (MSFT), Nvidia (NVDA).
 - **How:** Explosive revenue growth alongside widening losses as facilities scale — watch capex intensity, backlog/contract duration, and any customer-concentration commentary.
 - **Link:** The Briefing (This Week's Earnings), 9 Aug 2026 — <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings>
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Also in the last 24 hours (quick hits)

- **Meta ordered to pay \$567M** in New Mexico after being found liable for harming teens' mental health — a fresh regulatory/liability marker for social platforms. Meta (META).
 - **China opened a cybersecurity review** of Palo Alto Networks products sold in the country — a geopolitical overhang for U.S. security vendors with China exposure. Palo Alto Networks (PANW). <https://www.theinformation.com/briefings>
 - **Cursor (Anysphere)** is reworking branding and other changes as a SpaceX acquisition nears — AI coding consolidation. <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/cursor-maps-out-branding-other-changes-spacex-acquisition-nears>
 - **U.S. robotics startups are smuggling China-made parts in luggage** amid supply constraints — hardware supply-chain fragility. <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/why-u-s-robotics-startups-stuffing-parts-china-luggage>
 - **AWS told engineers to cut CPU waste amid a capacity crunch** — even the largest cloud is rationing compute. Amazon (AMZN). <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/aws-tells-engineers-cut-cpu-waste-amid-crunch>
 - **Anthropic/OpenAI IPO wealth** could ripple into unusual places (SF real estate, private jets, niche philanthropy) — a lens on the coming AI liquidity wave. <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/anthropic-ipo-could-mean-shrimp-welfare-other-obscure-causes>
 - **Google's AI shake-up "boosts Brin"; Wall Street rethinks AI-debt bond sales** — flagged in "What We're Reading."
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Overall Summary — Trend, Development & Sentiment

The through-line across today's editions is that **the AI trade is maturing from "who buys the most GPUs" into "who converts AI into durable revenue, and who controls the scarce inputs — power, land and grid."** Software is visibly separating into monetisers (Palantir, Shopify) and share-donors (Canva, Figma, Datadog-with-an-asterisk), and investors are rewarding proof of monetisation over narrative. On the infrastructure side, the story is capital discipline and accounting optics: Microsoft's cash-flow "prudence" is real but partly engineered via longer depreciation schedules and heavy neocloud leasing, which trades near-term cash for long-term price exposure. Simultaneously, the physical world is pushing back — 500+ local data-center bans and statewide moves in New York and Texas — which raises the strategic premium on power (Nvidia's Lancium stake) and on developers that already hold interconnects.

Sentiment is constructive but increasingly discriminating. Enthusiasm remains strong in applied/vertical AI (Harvey's 40% valuation step-up in five months; neocloud triple-digit growth), yet the tape is quick to punish any hint of decelerating growth or customer concentration (Datadog -19% in a day; Figma -38% YTD). The mood is "show me the monetisation and the power," not "buy everything AI."

Important Questions & Risks Being Asked — and Addressed

- **Is software's AI edge defensible, or will foundation models eat point tools?** Addressed: Canva (losing to ChatGPT) and Figma (guidance stall) show substitution risk is real; the moat is proprietary data + embedded workflow (Palantir, Shopify), not features alone.
 - **Is Microsoft's capex "discipline" genuine or cosmetic?** Addressed: partly cosmetic — a 15–25-year useful-life change and lease reclassification shift spend from capex to opex; underlying spend and Nvidia orders are intact, with capex still guided +43% to >\$50B in Q1 FY27.
 - **What caps the AI buildout?** Addressed: increasingly the physical grid — 500+ local bans, New York/Texas actions — making power and interconnects the binding constraint, and a reason capital is flowing into power developers.
 - **Is the "rent-vs-build" model a hidden liability?** Addressed: Microsoft's ≥\$60B neocloud commitments preserve cash now but expose it to future price hikes; whether it can build enough owned capacity in 3–5 years to not "need neocloud" is the open question. CoreWeave/Nebius earnings this week are the near-term tell.
 - **Are private AI valuations stretched?** Open/skewed bullish: Harvey at \$15.5B on ~\$350M revenue (~44x) reflects momentum but concentrates risk if growth normalises.
 - **Rising non-fundamental risks:** regulation/liability (Meta's \$567M ruling), geopolitics (China's Palo Alto review), and AI-debt digestion in credit markets.
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Potential Investment Implications (companies directly mentioned)

Not investment advice — factual synthesis of names in today's coverage for further diligence.

Constructive / relative winners

- **Palantir (PLTR), Shopify (SHOP):** Named AI monetisers with re-accelerating growth; the clearest "AI is additive" software stories. Watch for durability of agent/consulting revenue (PLTR) and AI-driven merchant GMV (SHOP).
- **Nvidia (NVDA):** Vertically integrating into power via Lancium; benefits both from compute demand and from de-risking the power bottleneck. Watch neocloud results as a demand proxy.
- **CoreWeave (CRWV), Nebius (NBIS):** Triple-digit revenue growth and key suppliers to Microsoft's rent model; high-beta plays on the compute-power scarcity theme — but widening losses and customer concentration are the swing factors this week (11–12 Aug).
- **Power/interconnect exposure (Lancium — private; Cipher Mining CIPR; Iren IREN; Lambda, Nscale — private):** Data-center bans elevate the value of firms that already control power and grid access.

Mixed / watch

- **Microsoft (MSFT):** Strong FCF optics and 29% stock gain, but “prudence” is partly accounting; long-run neocloud price exposure and future depreciation drag bear monitoring.
- **Amazon (AMZN), Alphabet/Google (GOOGL):** Heavier owned-infrastructure spend pressured near-term cash (AMZN’s CPU-waste crackdown signals a crunch); Google’s \$30B SpaceX capacity deal and data-center-ban exposure (as a named buyer) cut both ways.
- **Datadog (DDOG):** Still a YTD winner but flagged “usage-down” risk from a large AI customer — the canonical “spend-less” churn worry.

Cautious

- **Figma (FIG), Canva (private):** Direct substitution risk from improving generative models; Figma -38% YTD embodies the de-rating.
- **Meta (META):** \$567M NM liability ruling adds to teen-safety legal overhang.
- **Palo Alto Networks (PANW):** China cybersecurity review introduces geopolitical/revenue risk in that market.

Private/thematic to track: Harvey (\$15.5B legal-AI round — vertical-AI valuation barometer), OpenAI & Anthropic (IPO pipeline and Stargate demand), Cursor/Anysphere (SpaceX M&A — AI-coding consolidation), Oracle (ORCL) & SpaceX (Stargate/compute buildout), Lyft (LYFT, featured on TITV post-Q2).

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